Ukraine. Orbán's conquest of Hungary continued with his re-election in 2014, in 2018 and again in 2022, and during this time he became a Europe-wide voice of social conservatism amd the European right, for example, through his contacts with Marine Le Pen. Given the commendation by Steve Bannon, Orbán positioned himself as a social conservative even on the global scale. 'The experience of gaining a global audience and lecturing affluent Western Europeans about the future of politics was intoxicating for the Hungarian leader. For decades, ever since the fall of the Berlin Wall, the post-Soviet countries had been cast in the role of students and supplicants. […] Now it was their turn.'[145] Or as Orbán proclaimed: 'We used to think that Europe was our future. Today we know that we are the future of Europe.'[146] This was no longer copying of the West; something original was coming from Central Europe, something declared as truly European – Central Europe was at the centre of attention indeed. 'In a spiritual sense, the West has moved to Central Europe,' said Orbán in a speech in July 2022. 'The two halves of Europe are locked in a battle… The West has rejected Central Europe's desire to allow each nation to live as they like, and they continue to fight Central Europe to change us to be like them,' he added.[147] (As a result of racist undertones in the same speech, a close collaborator of Orbán decided to resign.) Orbán's position on the global conservative scene was again confirmed in his prominent appearance at the annual Conservative Political Action Conference (CPAC) in the United States in August 2022.[148]

One may label Mr Orbán a populist (or worse), but to any populist, real (and not just alleged, as it was the case during the Communist times) support is essential. And that support in Hungary (as in Poland) appears to be real, not enforced or only bought with perks. Only to condemn it, does little good; one has to understand the drivers for such trends. The 'threat' of migrants, the urban-rural divide, the nostalgia for a far greater pre-Trianon Hungary (and lack of reflection on the feelings of non-Hungarian peoples ruled by Hungarians, sometimes in brutal fashion, as was the case during World War II in Hungarian-occupied zones), and the preference for traditional values have been already mentioned. Lendvai adds that liberal and left-wing parties were also not able to present a clear and credible political agenda,[149] something that, as we shall see, also played a role in Poland.